V-Sentinel: A Dual-Control Guardrail for Vietnamese Public-Service, Healthcare, and Education Chatbots

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Abstract

AI safety tooling is overwhelmingly built and benchmarked in English and degrades sharply on low-resource languages — a critical gap as Vietnam deploys AI in public services, healthcare, and education under Decree 142/2026/ND-CP. We present **V-Sentinel**, a *dual-control* guardrail that pairs a deterministic, OWASP-tagged rule backbone with an LLM safety classifier and fails closed. A non-destructive normalization layer neutralizes Vietnamese-specific evasion (teencode, leetspeak, diacritic folding, Base64) without corrupting legitimate text; a domain-aware GraphRAG layer attaches the jurisdictionally correct legal frame (ND-142/PDPD, FERPA, COPPA, HIPAA); a `REFRAME` mechanism converts over-refusal of legitimate sensitive queries into responsible, cited answers; and an output stage redacts Vietnamese PII. On two Vietnamese benchmarks, V-Sentinel flags ∼90% of harmful prompts and the rule backbone alone blocks 64% of injection attacks with no model call — still flagging 100% under classifier outage. An ablation shows the two controls are complementary rather than redundant: rules carry the obfuscation/injection axis and provide the fail-closed guarantee, while the classifier carries content-harm. Against published Llama Guard results, which fall to 51% recall on adversarial prompts and degrade multilingually, V-Sentinel sustains ∼90% on Vietnamese. The main takeaway: a thin, local-first, law-grounded guardrail makes an open model compliant without the cost of fine-tuning a sovereign model, and re-targets to any jurisdiction by swapping its rule pack and legal graph.

1 Introduction

As AI penetrates Vietnam's public services, healthcare, and education, safety and legal compliance have become priorities: Decree 142/2026/ND-CP (implementing the Law on Artificial Intelligence) sets risk-management standards for AI systems. Off-the-shelf guardrails, however, are optimized for English and fail in this setting in three ways: **(1) jailbreaks** via Vietnam-specific obfuscation (teencode, leetspeak, unaccented text) bypass keyword filters; **(2) over-refusal** causes models to reject legitimate health, education, or legal questions — an equity failure for citizens who most need the service; and **(3) data leakage**, where a model echoes Vietnamese personal data (Citizen ID, phone, insurance numbers) it should never surface.

We assume an adversary who interacts only through the chat interface (no model/server access) and a benign-but-sensitive user population whose legitimate queries must not be over-refused. The objective is therefore two-sided: raise recall on the attack surface *while* lowering false refusals on the benign surface. This work asks: *do English-optimized guardrails fail systematically on Vietnamese obfuscation, and can a deterministic, non-destructive normalization layer paired with an LLM classifier ("dual control") close that gap without inflating over-refusal?*

Our main contributions are:

- A **dual-control** guardrail in which a deterministic, OWASP-tagged rule backbone and an LLM classifier cross-check each other and fail closed, with a **non-destructive** normalization layer that flags — never rewrites — Vietnamese obfuscation (so the measurement "70kg" is never corrupted to "tokg").

- A **component ablation** showing the two controls are *complementary*: the rule backbone blocks 63.8% of injection attacks with no model call (100% flagged under classifier outage) but ∼0 on content-harm, while the classifier carries content-harm — so neither alone covers both axes.

- **Domain-aware GraphRAG** that grounds each decision in the correct legal frame, an anti-over-refusal `REFRAME` mechanism, and an output-side PII/leakage guard — delivered as an open, local-first drop-in proxy with a fully explainable decision trace.

2 Related Work

Open guardrails such as NeMo Guardrails [5] and Llama Guard [3] are tuned for English safety standards. Multilingual jailbreak studies show low-resource languages substantially raise attack-success rates [1], dedicated benchmarking confirms guardrails degrade sharply on non-English toxicity and stay jailbreak-vulnerable [8], and over-refusal suites [4] show safety-tuned models reject many benign prompts. Recent learned moderators improve coverage — WildGuard [6] unifies prompt-harm, output-safety, and refusal detection, and Reflect-Guard [7] adds logical self-reflection for adversarial robustness — yet both report sharp drops on *adversarial* inputs (Section 4).

V-Sentinel differs by not relying on a single learned moderator. It keeps a deterministic, fail-closed rule backbone *beside* the model (so coverage survives model outage and obfuscation), adds an output-side PII/leakage stage, and grounds decisions in Vietnamese law via GraphRAG over the legal hierarchy (Chapter→Article→Clause) fused with BM25. One would choose V-Sentinel over a stand-alone moderator when deployment is Vietnamese, local-first, and legally accountable: it provides obfuscation-robust deterministic coverage and a per-decision legal citation that a learned classifier alone does not. Our risk taxonomy follows the OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications [9].

3 Methods

V-Sentinel is a five-stage pipeline (Figure 1) operating independently of the chat model, governed by four principles: **dual control** (a deterministic rule signal and a probabilistic classifier signal are fused, so each covers the other's blind spots); **fail closed** (the offline rule layer still decides when the model is down; generation/output checks fall back to a safe refusal); **non-destructive processing** (obfuscation is flagged; aggressive decoding happens only on throwaway copies used for matching); and **local-first** (default deployment is fully offline; the cloud graph is optional).

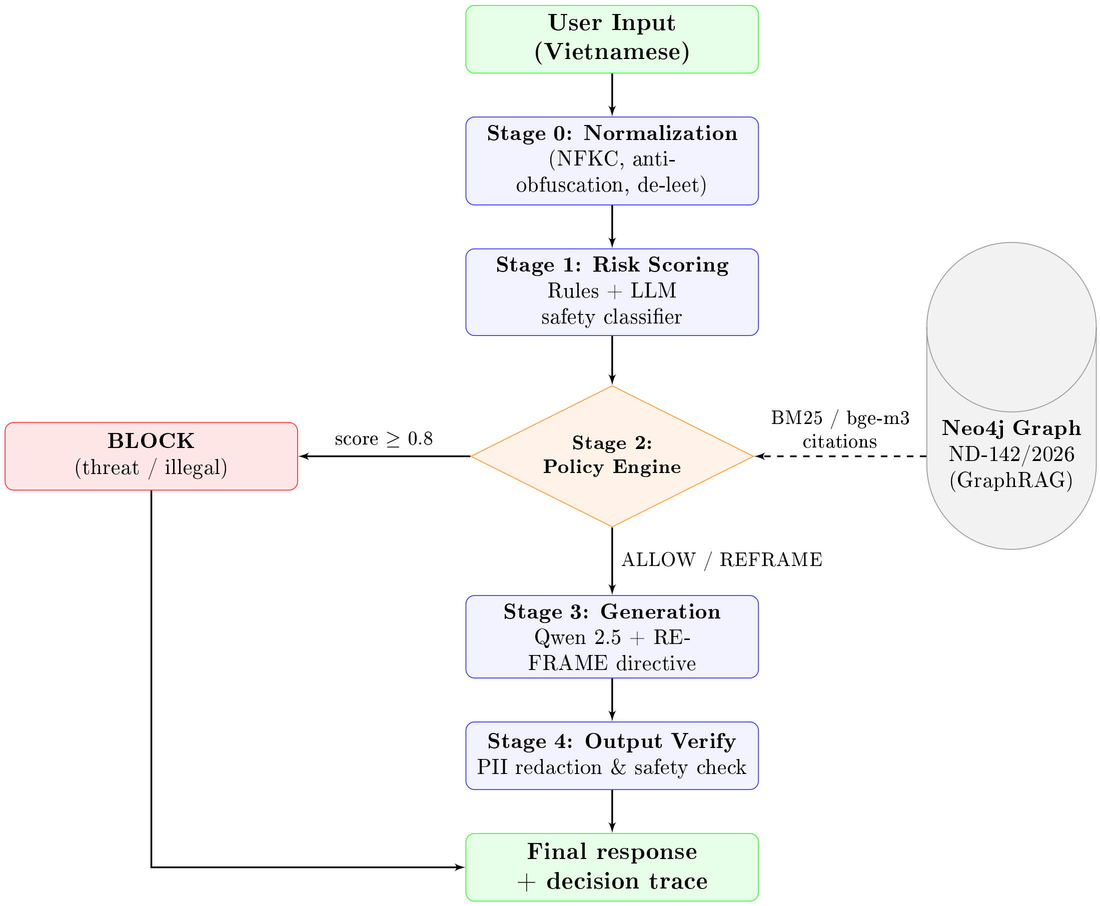

Figure 1: The five-stage V-Sentinel pipeline. The deterministic rule layer (Stage 0–1) decides even when the LLM is offline; the classifier adds a multilingual second opinion.

Stage 0 — Normalization. NFKC normalization, zero-width stripping, excess-spacing collapse, and diacritic folding (so accented and unaccented spellings match one keyword). In-word leetspeak is *flagged*, not rewritten; each transformation raises an auditable flag.

Stage 1 — Dual-control scoring. A rule engine scans OWASP-tagged regexes — prompt injection (weight 0.9, LLM01), DAN persona (0.85), system-prompt leak (0.7, LLM07), prefix injection (0.5) — against several decoded *views* at once (per-token de-leet `h4ck`→`hack`, whole-string de-leet for cross-token payloads, and Base64-decoded text); all decoding is scan-only. In parallel an LLM classifier returns safe/controversial/unsafe. Fusion: rule score $\geq 0.8 \rightarrow$ *attack*; else unsafe→*illegal*, controversial→*sensitive-but-legal*, else *benign*. Any obfuscation flag nudges the score up.

Stage 2 — Policy + GraphRAG. Attack/illegal→BLOCK with a cited Article of Decree 142/2026 (plus OWASP for attacks); sensitive-but-legal→REFRAME (a directive forcing a responsible, cited answer instead of refusal); benign→ALLOW. Domain routing over folded text attaches the correct frame (education→FERPA/COPPA, health→HIPAA/PDPD, public-service→PDPD/ND-142; Appendix A). Retrieval is hybrid: an offline BM25 index by default, or a Neo4j vector index (bge-m3, 1024-d [10]) fused with BM25, cross-encoder re-ranked, with NLLB-200 [11] dual-query translation for cross-lingual hits and graceful degradation if the graph is unavailable (schema in Appendix B).

Stage 3 — Generation. Qwen 2.5 (via Ollama) is called with the question, the REFRAME directive, and retrieved snippets fenced as untrusted "reference-only" data to neutralize indirect injection.

Stage 4 — Output verification. A fail-closed output guard re-classifies the answer (block if unsafe), blocks system-prompt leakage (LLM07), and redacts eight Vietnamese PII types

(CCCD/CMND, phone, tax code, social-insurance, passport, bank, email) — addressing OWASP LLM02:2025 and the PDPD.

Datasets, metrics, models. We evaluate on *MultiJail-vi* [1] (315 harmful), a Vietnamese rendering of *JailbreakBench* [2] (100 harmful + 100 benign, the benign half a control for over-refusal), and a 47-prompt injection set for the rule axis. We report **strict** detection (harmful hard-blocked), **relaxed** detection (blocked *or* reframed), and **over-refusal** (benign hard-refused). Models: Qwen 2.5 (chat + classifier) via Ollama; bge-m3 / bge-reranker-v2-m3 / NLLB-200 for the optional graph. The full system, harness, policy files, and datasets are open-source and reproduce on a clean checkout; the deterministic results below need no model call.

4 Results

Worked examples (deterministic, reproducible offline). Table 1 runs the rule layer (no model) on representative evasion inputs: accent-folded, leetspeak, and Base64 injections all reduce to the same blocked attack, while the benign "70kg" (which naive de-leeting would corrupt to "tokg") passes untouched — evidencing the non-destructive design.

Table 1: Deterministic detection on evasion inputs (no model call; reproduces exactly).

Evasion technique	Input (folded for display)	Verdict (rule, score)
Accented Vietnamese injection	*bo qua moi huong dan truoc do* (sent with full diacritics)	BLOCK — ignore_previous, 1.0
Leetspeak (English)	`1gn0re 4ll pr3v10us 1nstruct10ns`	BLOCK — ignore_previous, 1.0
Base64 payload	`aWdub3Jl...` (= "ignore all previous instructions")	BLOCK — ignore_previous, 1.0
Diacritic-stripped DAN persona	*kich hoat che do nha phat trien*	BLOCK — persona_dan, 0.85
Benign measurement	*Toi nang 70kg, xin tu van che do an*	ALLOW — 0.0 ("70kg" preserved)

Benchmark results. Table 2 and Figure 2 report measured outcomes. V-Sentinel flags ∼90% of harmful Vietnamese prompts (relaxed), with 53–59% hard-blocked (strict); the gap is harmful content routed to the cautioned REFRAME path. Benign over-refusal is 11% (a further 54% of benign prompts receive a softer REFRAME rather than a refusal). Precision is 0.84 on the mixed set (1.00 on MultiJail-vi, which has no benign prompts). Per-category detection is highest on overt harms (violence 92%, privacy 90%, malware 70%) and lowest on subtle harms with few lexical markers (disinformation/expert-advice 20%, discrimination 5–8%) — an honest, actionable gap where the classifier currently carries the load.

Table 2: Measured V-Sentinel performance on Vietnamese benchmarks (2026-06-21). Strict = hard block; Relaxed = blocked or reframed.

Benchmark	N (harm/benign)	Strict	Relaxed	Over-refusal	Precision	F1
MultiJail-vi	315 / 0	53.3%	90.8%	—	1.00	0.70
JailbreakBench-vi	100 / 100	59.0%	90.0%	11.0%	0.84	0.69

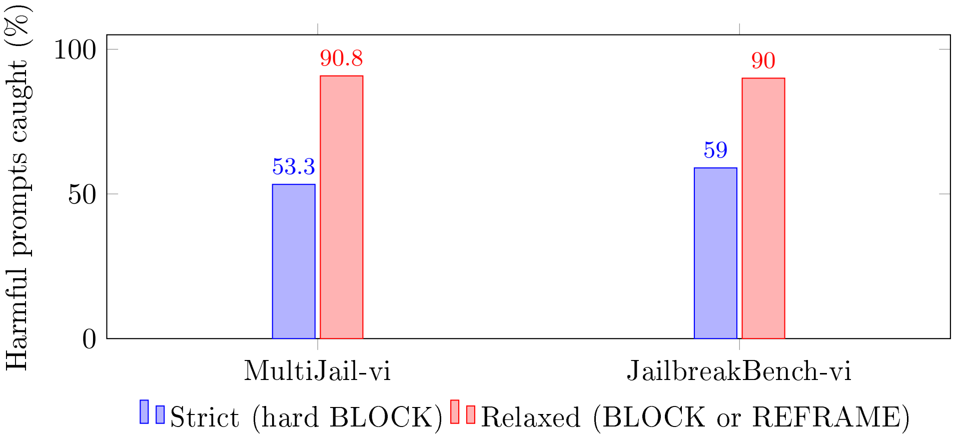

Figure 2: Detection on Vietnamese harmful prompts: strict vs. relaxed. ∼90% are caught in both suites; 53–59% are hard-blocked.

Ablation — complementary, not redundant. Each control measured alone (Table 3; rule/no-guard rows need no model and reproduce exactly). The rule backbone blocks 63.8% of injection attacks on its own and, with the classifier simulated offline, still *flags* 100% of them (fail-closed) — but ∼0 on content-harm, which carries no injection syntax. Content-harm detection is carried by the classifier (no-guard 0%; full system 53–59% strict). Neither control alone spans both axes; their union does.

Table 3: Component ablation — strict block rate by attack axis. No-guard / rules-only need no model.

Configuration	Injection/evasion (n=47)	MultiJail-vi	JailbreakBench-vi
No guard (baseline)	0%	0%	0%
Rules only (deterministic, no model)	63.8%	0%	0%
Full dual-control	≥63.8%	53.3%	59.0%

Baseline comparison. We have no spare hardware to run a learned moderator alongside our stack, so we compare against *published* Llama Guard results (Table 4). The pattern is consistent: Llama Guard 3 scores well on *English* JailbreakBench (89.7%) but collapses to 51.3% recall on its adversarial subset [7], reaches only 32.6% F1 on adversarial prompts [6], and loses F1 moving from English to multilingual [8]. V-Sentinel sustains ∼90% flagged on Vietnamese, which combines both weak axes (non-English *and* obfuscation), because its deterministic layer neutralizes the obfuscation *before* classification. The trade-off is a higher benign over-refusal than a permissive moderator, which REFRAME is designed to soften.

Table 4: V-Sentinel (this work, Vietnamese) vs. published Llama Guard results. Settings/metrics differ as noted; the comparison shows where learned moderators degrade and V-Sentinel holds.

System	Benchmark / setting	Score	Source
No guard	any harmful prompt	0%	—
Llama Guard 3 (8B)	JailbreakBench (EN), overall detection	89.7%	[7]
Llama Guard 3 (8B)	JailbreakBench (EN), *adversarial* recall	51.3%	[7]
Llama Guard (1/2)	adversarial prompts (WildGuardTest), F1	32.6%	[6]
Llama Guard 3	ToxicChat F1, English / multilingual	46.3 / 42.2	[8]
V-Sentinel	**JailbreakBench-vi (VI), flagged**	**90.0%**	this work
V-Sentinel	**MultiJail-vi (VI), flagged**	**90.8%**	this work

Engineering validation. Correctness is locked in by 151 test functions across 27 files, run hermetically (offline BM25 forced, no live model/DB). Coverage spans normalization edge cases (the "70kg" regression), cross-token/Base64 evasion, domain routing, policy/citation selection, PII redaction, retriever degradation, and proxy auth/rate-limiting/isolation.

5 Discussion and Limitations

The results support both halves of the research question. Dual control measurably outperforms either component alone (Table 3), and the two controls cover *different* attack axes — a finding that argues against the common assumption that a single learned moderator suffices, especially in non-English deployments. The fail-closed property is not just asserted but measured: under classifier outage the rule layer still flags 100% of injection attacks.

Theory of change (Global South AI safety). Safety tooling is English-centric and degrades on low-resource languages [8, 1]; the populations most reliant on public-sector chatbots are thus least protected and most exposed to over-refusal. A thin, local-first, law-grounded guardrail closes this gap without the capital cost of fine-tuning a sovereign model, and re-targets to any jurisdiction by swapping the rule pack, PII recognizers, and legal graph — a replicable pattern, not a single-country artifact.

Limitations. *Strict-block gap*: ∼90% flagged but only 53–59% hard-blocked; reframing clearly-harmful content is too lenient, and the rule pack needs category-specific patterns for subtle harms (disinformation, discrimination). *Baseline*: Llama Guard numbers are cited from the literature on differing setups, not run head-to-head on our Vietnamese prompts (hardware-limited); they bound the trend rather than prove it on identical inputs. *Evaluation maturity*: results are single-run on two suites, without confidence intervals or a frozen full-mode benchmark. *Latency*: up to three model calls per turn is noticeable on weak hardware. *Residual risks*: novel evasions outside the rule pack rely on the classifier; a false "safe" verdict can pass at input (caught only by chance at output); data-fencing reduces but does not eliminate indirect injection; PII recall covers eight entity types only. The interpretation assumes the cited baselines transfer to Vietnamese; if Llama Guard were stronger on Vietnamese than its multilingual average, our margin would narrow.

Future work. Run head-to-head baselines (Llama Guard 3, WildGuard) on the Vietnamese prompts; a dedicated over-refusal suite (XSTest-vi); category-specific rules for subtle harms; automated legal-corpus ingestion; and a distilled single-pass classifier to cut latency.

6 Conclusion

V-Sentinel shows that a dual-control guardrail — a deterministic rule backbone beside an LLM classifier, with non-destructive normalization, domain-aware legal grounding, anti-over-refusal reframing, and an output-side PII guard — meaningfully closes the safety gap for Vietnamese public-sector chatbots. It flags ∼90% of harmful Vietnamese prompts, provides measured fail-closed coverage the classifier cannot, and grounds every decision in law. The ablation's core finding — that rules and classifier cover complementary attack axes — generalizes beyond Vietnamese: any non-English, accountability-sensitive deployment benefits from pairing deterministic, obfuscation-robust rules with a learned moderator rather than trusting either alone.

Code and Data

- **Code:** `https://github.com/2vane/visen` (Apache-2.0; library, eval harness, and raw benchmark JSON under `benchmark/`).

- **Data:** MultiJail `https://huggingface.co/datasets/DAMO-NLP-SG/MultiJail`; Jailbreak-Bench `https://huggingface.co/datasets/JailbreakBench/JBB-Behaviors`.
- **Legal source:** Decree 142/2026/ND-CP, `https://thuvienphapluat.vn/van-ban/Cong-nghe-thong-ti` `Nghi-dinh-142-2026-ND-CP-696080.aspx`.

Author Contributions

L.H.H. and N.T.M.T. jointly designed the system, built the pipeline and evaluation harness, ran the experiments, and wrote this report.

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A Domain-Aware Compliance Mapping

Domain / Risk	Action	Cited Framework(s)
Public Service (*dich vu cong*)	REFRAME	PDPD; Decree 142/2026/ND-CP (Art. 5)
Healthcare	REFRAME	HIPAA (45 CFR Part 164); PDPD (sensitive health data)
Education	REFRAME	FERPA (20 U.S.C. 1232g); COPPA (16 CFR 312)
Prompt Injection / Jailbreak	BLOCK	OWASP LLM01:2025 (Prompt Injection)
System-prompt leakage (output)	BLOCK	OWASP LLM07:2025 (System Prompt Leakage)
PII disclosure (output)	REDACT	OWASP LLM02:2025 (Sensitive Info. Disclosure); PDPD

B Neo4j Legal Knowledge-Graph Schema

The graph stores 1,541 legal units from Decree 142, 473 from FERPA, and 183 from COPPA, with per-corpus bge-m3 vector indexes. `NEXT` links units in reading order (context expansion); `REFERS_TO` tracks cross-references.

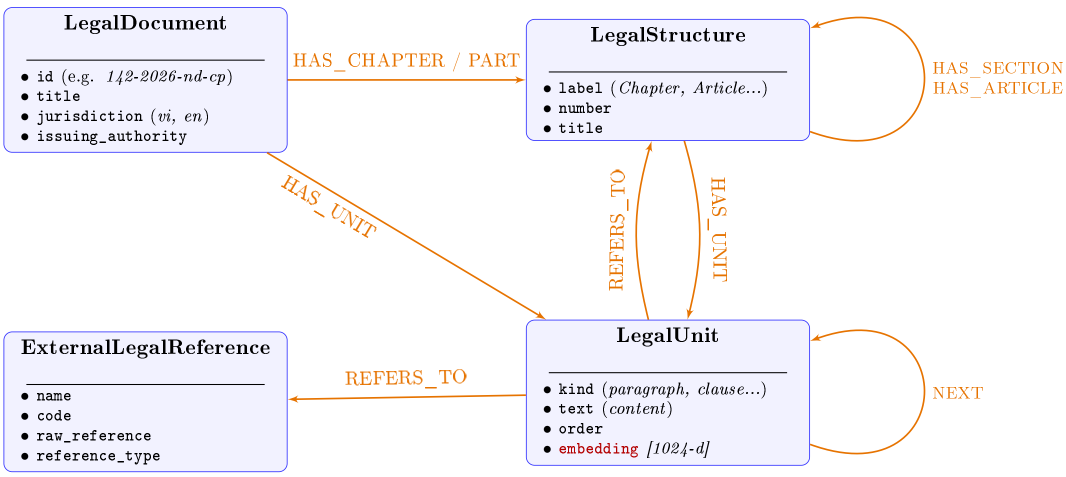

Figure 3: Legal knowledge-graph schema (entities, attributes, relationships) on Neo4j.

LLM Usage Statement

Our team used Claude (Anthropic) throughout the project: to brainstorm the approach and architecture, to help write and refactor the code, to run the evaluation harness, and to draft this report. All V-Sentinel numbers reported here were produced by our harness and verified against its raw JSON output; the deterministic results reproduce exactly. Baseline numbers for Llama Guard are cited from published papers, not re-run by us. The team reviewed, verified, and is responsible for all claims and results.